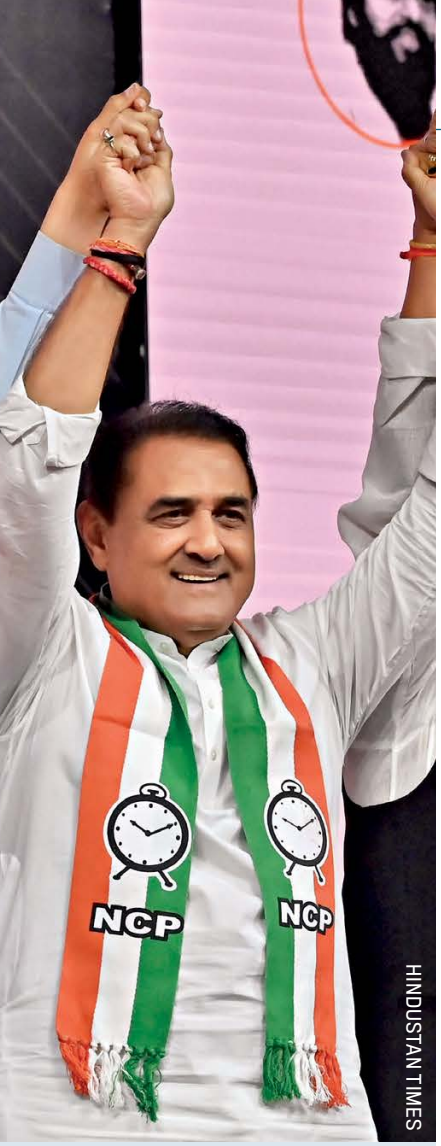


HINDUSTAN TIMES

THE CRACKS ARE SHOWING

- Chief minister Eknath Shinde has the support of 13 Lok Sabha MPs and deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar of just one. Yet, Ajit's NCP has managed to secure more favourable terms from the BJP
- Both BJP and Ajit faction leaders are opposing Shinde's candidates in seats like Maval
- The Sena was forced to concede strongholds like Dharashiv (Osmanabad) and Parbhani. Demands are being made to give up more seats like Nashik, Thane, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar (Aurangabad)
- Intense political tussles between Shinde Sena and BJP in districts like Thane. Ganpat Gaikwad, the MLA from Kalyan, shot at and Shinde faction leader Mahesh Gaikwad injured inside a police station at Ulhasnagar on Feb. 2
- Shinde's men fear that the knives may be out for them in the BJP in the state assembly polls due later this year
- The Mahayuti is working hard to placate disgruntled leaders like Uttam Jankar (Madha) and former minister Prakash Awade (Hatkanangale), who could have upset the equations
- The splits in the Shiv Sena and NCP, defections of leaders like Ashok Chavan (Congress) and the "unconditional" support of MNS chief Raj Thackeray to the ruling alliance have created a perception that the BJP is on a weak wicket and is hence working hard to build new alliances

TWO IS COMPANY AND THREE A CROWD, they say. It is something the three-party 'Mahayuti' in Maharashtra is discovering, as pulls and pressures within the grand alliance of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP), the Shinde faction of the Shiv Sena and the Ajit Pawar faction of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) are threatening to come to a head just before the general election.

The first major embarrassment came when chief minister Eknath Shinde went by his script and announced incumbent MP Hemant Patil's name from Hingoli in the first list of candidates and then, following opposition from the local BJP unit, had to replace him with Baburao Kadam Kohalikar. Patil was among the 13 MPs who quit the parent Sena along with Shinde in June 2022, and had been reportedly assured of a renomination. To placate him, his wife Rajshri has now been nominated from neighbouring Yavatmal-Washim, in place of five-term Sena MP Bhavana Gawali Patil. That, in turn, has upset Bhavana, who has clout among the local Kunbis, though she has said she will campaign for the party. Meanwhile, BJP leader Shivaji Jadhav was not mollified with Kohalikar either, as he wanted Hingoli for himself, and has rebelled. Shinde has also replaced Ramtek MP Krupal Tumane with Congress turncoat Raju Parwe, reportedly at the BJP's behest. The BJP has also managed to wrest the traditional Shiv Sena stronghold of Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg from the Shinde Sena, nominating Union minister Narayan Rane over state industries minister Uday Samant's brother Kiran, who was set for a contest. Rane will take on incumbent MP Vinayak Raut of the residuary Sena (UBT), led by Uddhav Thackeray.

In Amravati, the BJP's Navneet Kaur Rana